

Photographs by M.R. NARAYANAN



much resistance, violence was averted but the workers withdrew from the area only after the state government put pressure on them to leave.

It was in 2003 that following a tribal agitation, the United Democratic Front (UDF) government allotted an acre of land each in Chinnakanal to more than 700 tribal families. However even after four years, only 540 families have received land. The remaining families have now decided to fight for their rights. They had launched an indefinite hunger strike in September but called it off after Minister for SC/ST Welfare A.K. Balan assured them that they would get their land in a month's time. When this promise too was not fulfilled, the tribals forcibly took over the land and set up the hutments.

UDF is now planning to exploit the issue for political gains. Led by Opposition leader Oomen Chandy, Congress workers uprooted CPI(M) flags and fences in Chinnakanal. "CPI(M) is trying to convert Chinnakanal into another Nandigram," he said. CPI(M), however, pooh-poohs his postures. "It was the UDF government which promised them land. Why didn't

Chandy, who was chief minister until 18 months ago, not do anything to carry out the promise?" snipes Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan.

Chinnakanal is not the first village in Kerala which has seen forced takeover of land by tribals. According to experts, majority of tribals and dalits are still landless despite the fact that the country's most comprehensive land reforms since 1964 have taken place in Kerala. The encroachments have mostly occurred in plantations which had been exempt from land reforms. Since August, 20,000 tribals have grabbed land and set up their hutments in the Chengara rubber estates in Pathanamthitta district owned by Harrisons Malayalam Plantations, the largest private land holding company in the state. "They have to shoot us down before they evict us from here," says Laha Gopalan, a tribal leader. In Kannur, hundreds of tribals have forcibly settled down in Aralam, a government-owned farm. The disputes do not look likely to end anytime soon since the state government too is hesitant to act on it, lest it become another Nandigram. ■

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